Second language processing of socially grounded verbal morphology: A case of subject honorification in Korean

Nayoung Kwon (University of Oregon, nkwon@uoregon.edu), Gyu-Ho Shin (University of Illinois Chicago), Sun Hee Park (Ewha Womans University)

Subject honorification in Korean marks respect toward the sentential subject via the verbal suffix -*(u)si*. Acquiring this system poses challenges because it requires establishing a non-local subject–predicate dependency while integrating syntactic, semantic, and social-pragmatic information. Unlike obligatory person/number agreement, honorific marking is optional and context-dependent, making this cue for subject–predicate relations relatively unreliable: honorifiable subjects do not always trigger honorification, but when used, -*(u)si* must agree with the subject's honorific status.

(1) halmeni-kkeyse iltung-ul ha-(si)-ess-eyo.
grandmother-NOM.HON first.place-ACC do-(SH)-PST-DCL
'The grandmother came in first place'

Two experiments explored how cultural background—coming from a language rich in honorifics (Japanese: JpL1, *n*=32) versus one largely without them (American: EngL1, *n*=42)—shapes learners' structural and socio-pragmatic understanding of Korean honorification. Study 1 manipulated subject honorification (honorific vs. non-honorific predicate) and subject type (honorifiable, non-honorifiable animate, inanimate). Participants rated the sentences for politeness (2). Study 2 tested whether learners could use the honorific cue to anticipate subject–verb agreement online, as native speakers do, in a self-paced reading task (3).

(2) sensayngnim-kkeyse/kkoma-ka/kulim-i kyosil-lo tuleka-(si)-ess-ta.
teacher-NOM.HON/kid-NOM/picture-NOM classroom-DIR enter-(SH)-PST-DCL
'The teacher/kid/picture entered the classroom.'

(3) kyosil-lo [tuleka-(si)-mye]$_{R3}$ [sensayngnim-kkeyse/kkoma-ka/kulim-i]$_{R4}$ …
classroom-DIR [enter-(SH)-while]$_{R3}$ [teacher-NOM.HON/kid-NOM/picture-NOM]$_{R4}$ …
'While the teacher/kid/picture entered the classroom, …'

Results (Study 1, Fig1). For NSK (*n*=20), subject and predicate types interacted: honorific predicates were rated as more polite only in the HON.subj condition ($p<.001$), indicating that native speakers condition politeness inferences on structural subject–predicate relations. In contrast, both learner groups rated honorific predicates as more polite than non-honorific predicates across all subject types (*p*s<.001), suggesting reliance on a generalized politeness heuristic rather than sensitivity to the agreement dependency in L2 sentence processing.

Results (Study 2, Fig2a&b). NSK (*n*=40) showed grammaticality effects (*p*s<.003): the HON.pred condition elicited longer reading times than the NH.pred condition for non-honorifiable subjects (INA.subj: W4; NH.subj: W6), consistent with detection of an agreement violation in online processing. In contrast, neither learner group showed the grammaticality effect observed in the native-speaker group. Nonetheless, both learner groups demonstrated sensitivity to honorific features, exhibiting longer reading times for non-honorific predicates than for honorific predicates (EngL1: W5 and W6, *p*s<.04; JpL1: W5, $p<.02$). All groups showed a semantic incongruity effect, with inanimate subjects eliciting longer reading times than animate subjects (*p*s<.001).

Overall, NSK processed subject honorification as a grammatical agreement relation, using -*(u)si* as a structural cue to evaluate dependencies during comprehension. By contrast, learners did not exhibit target-like, structure-based sensitivity; instead, they relied primarily on the politeness function of -*(u)si*, treating it as a general politeness marker rather than a reliable subject–predicate agreement cue during processing. Notably, this pattern held even for learners whose L1 features a rich honorific system with subject honorification. Across learner groups, semantic incongruity effects for inanimate subjects suggest shared access to plausibility constraints despite divergent weighting of grammatical cues. Together, these findings show how optional and low-reliability morphological cue at the syntax–pragmatics interface poses particular challenges for L2 sentence processing and differentially constrains L1 and L2 processing.

Table 1. Subject−predicate combinations used for politeness rating and self-paced reading

Subject	Predicate	Acceptable?
H_{subj}	H_{pred}	Yes
	NH_{pred}	Yes
NH_{subj}	H_{pred}	No (Structural anomaly)
	NH_{pred}	Yes
INA_{subj}	H_{pred}	No (Semantic anomaly)
	NH_{pred}	No (Semantic anomaly)

Note. Two control conditions with an inanimate subject were included for each predicate type, creating semantic anomaly conditions. No test stimuli included addressee honorification.

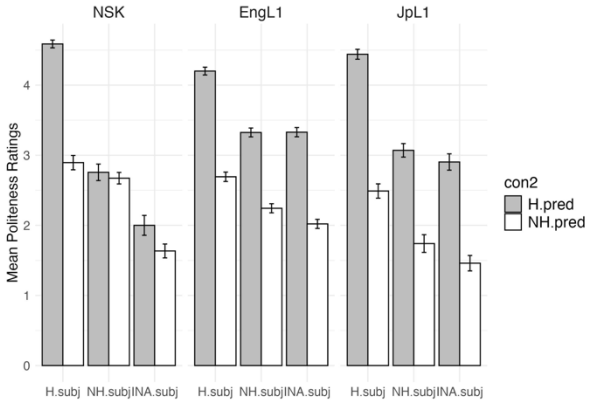


Fig 1. Politeness Rating (6-point scale: 1= very impolite; 5= very polite)

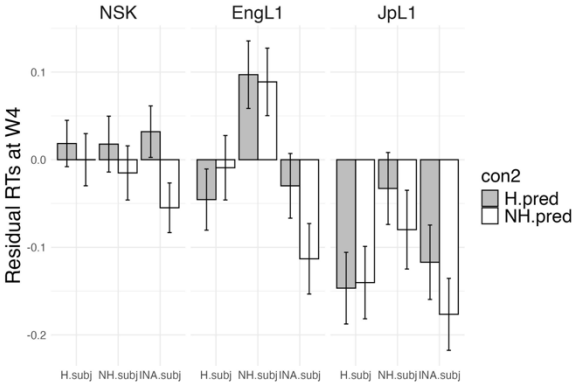
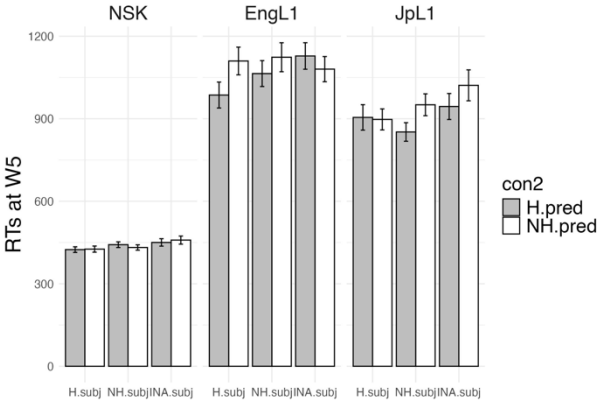


Fig 2a. Self-Paced Reading (at the critical region)
(Residual RTs to adjust word length difference and individual reading speed)



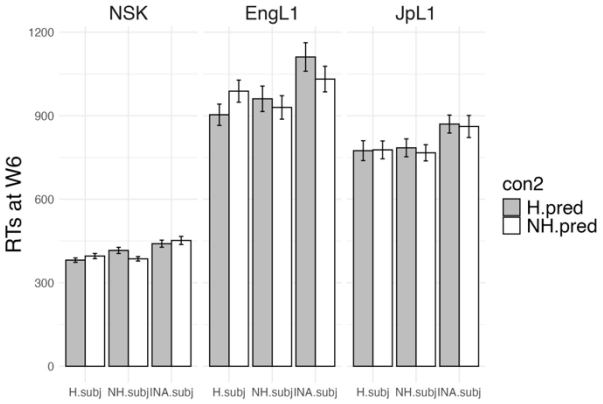


Fig 2b. Self-Paced Reading (spill-over regions). Ourliers were removed (<140ms or > 4000ms), RTs were log-transformed, and data points beyond 3SDs were excluded.

NSK = native speakers of Korean, EngL1 = English-speaking learners of Korean; JpL1 = Japanese-speaking learners of Korean.

Abbreviations. ACC = accusative case marker; DCL = predicate ending, declarative; DIR = directional marker; H = honorific; HON = honorific feature; SH = subject honorific suffix; INA = inanimate; NH = non-honorific; NOM = nominative case marker; PRED = predicate; PST = past tense marker; SUBJ = subject.